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Percentages tricks — Numbers 81 to 92

Each passage is now a mini-lesson: a challenge to hook them in, the trick, one worked example, two for the child to try, then both checked together — with encouragement all the way through. Read it like you're at the kitchen table and someone just asked "go on then, show me".

The four rules

1. Before each passage say its number clearly — "Number one", "Number two" — pause a second, read the passage, then pause a couple of seconds before the next number. Those gaps are how I find the joins. 2. Wherever you see ... leave a short beat — two seconds is plenty. Those are the "have a think" moments for the kids. 3. If you stumble, don't stop the recording: pause, say the SAME number again, and read that passage again. I'll keep your retake. 4. Kitchen-table warmth beats newsreader polish every time.

Total is roughly two hours of reading — absolutely fine to do over several sittings (each take just needs to start at a numbered item; tick them off on the printed version as you go). When done, drop the audio file(s) — m4a, mp3, wav, anything — into OneDrive Times tables/recordings and tell me.

Tick each number as you record it so you can pick up where you left off.

Part F — Percentages tricks

■ Say: "Number 81" — 10% — Shift the Decimal

Quick one — what's 10 percent of 360? ... If you said 36 in a heartbeat, you already know the most important percentage trick there is. If not, brilliant timing — because this one unlocks nearly everything else. 10 percent means 1 out of every 10, so finding 10 percent is just dividing by 10. And the quickest way to divide by 10 is to move the decimal point one place to the left. Let's do 10 percent of 360. Picture the decimal point sitting after the 360. Slide it one place left and you get 36. So 10 percent of 360 is 36. That's the whole trick — one little slide. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 10 percent of 250? ... and what's 10 percent of 42? ... Have a proper go before I tell you. Right — 10 percent of 250: slide the decimal point one place left and 250 becomes 25. So 10 percent of 250 is 25. And 10 percent of 42: slide the point one place left and 42 becomes 4.2. So 10 percent of 42 is 4.2 — the point just tucks in between the 4 and the 2. See? You've got this one — and almost every other percentage is built from it, so go smash the practice.

■ Say: "Number 82" — 1% — Shift TWICE

Quick one — what's 1% of 300? ... If that popped out in a few seconds, you already know this trick. If not, no bother at all — you'll have it in a minute. Here's the idea. 1% means 1 out of every 100, so finding 1% is just dividing by 100. And the speedy way to divide by 100 is to move the decimal point two places to the left. That's the whole trick. Let's do 1% of 300. Slide the decimal point two places left, and 300 becomes 3. So 1% of 300 is 3. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 1% of 500? ... and what's 1% of 62? ... Have a proper go before I tell you. ... Ready? 1% of 500: move the decimal point two places left, and 500 becomes 5. So 1% of 500 is 5. Now 1% of 62: two hops left turns 62 into 0.62. So 1% of 62 is 0.62. And here's the best bit — once you can find 1%, you can build any percentage at all. See? Two little hops and you're there — go smash the practice.

■ Say: "Number 83" — % ↔ Fraction Magic

Here's a quick one — what's 25% of 80? ... Got it in under ten seconds? Then you already think like this trick. If not, stick with me — it's a lovely one. The secret is that some percentages are really fractions in disguise. 50% is a half, 25% is a quarter, 75% is three quarters, 20% is a fifth, and 10% is a tenth. Swap the percentage for its fraction and the sum turns easy. So, 25% of 80: 25% is a quarter, and a quarter of 80 is 80 divided by 4, which is 20. So 25% of 80 is 20 — no long working, just one divide. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 50% of 90? ... and what's 20% of 35? ... Have a proper think before I tell you. ... Right, let's check. 50% is a half, and half of 90 is 45. So 50% of 90 is 45. Now 20% is a fifth, and 35 divided by 5 is 7. So 20% of 35 is 7. That's it — you now know a shortcut plenty of grown-ups still reach for a calculator to do.

■ Say: "Number 84" — Build from 10, 5 and 1

Try this — what's 15% of 60? ... If you rattled that off, brilliant, you've already got the idea. If it felt tricky, don't worry — this trick makes it easy. You can build any percentage out of little blocks: 10%, 5% and 1%. 10% is just divide by 10, 5% is half of your 10%, and 1% is divide by 100. Stack the blocks until you reach the percentage you want. So, 15% of 60. 10% of 60 is 6. 5% is half of that, which is 3. Add them: 6 plus 3 is 9. So 15% of 60 is 9. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 15% of 40? ... and what's 12% of 300? ... Have a proper go first. ... Let's check together. 15% of 40: 10% of 40 is 4, 5% is half of that, 2, and 4 plus 2 is 6. So 15% of 40 is 6. Now 12% of 300: 10% of 300 is 30, 1% is 3, so 2% is 6, and 30 plus 6 is 36. So 12% of 300 is 36. See? Little blocks, big answers — you've got this one.

■ Say: "Number 85" — Halve and Double

Quick challenge — what's 20% of 45? ... If that came out in under ten seconds, you're already halfway to mastering this. If not, no stress — let's learn it right now. The trick is to find 10% first, by dividing by 10. Then two quick moves unlock loads more: halve the 10% to get 5%, or double it to get 20%. Most everyday percentages are just a halve or a double away. So, 20% of 45. 10% of 45 is 4.5. Double it: 4.5 plus 4.5 is 9. So 20% of 45 is 9. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 5% of 60? ... and what's 20% of 35? ... Have a proper go before I spill the answers. ... Okay, checking time. 5% of 60: 10% of 60 is 6, and half of 6 is 3. So 5% of 60 is 3. Now 20% of 35: 10% of 35 is 3.5, and double 3.5 is 7. So 20% of 35 is 7. See? Find 10%, then halve or double — that's most percentages sorted for life. Go smash the practice.

■ Say: "Number 86" — Swap the Numbers

Here's a sneaky one — what's 4% of 50? ... If you got 2 straight away, you might already know this magic. If it looked horrible, perfect — watch this. There's a magical fact about percentages: a certain percent of one number is always the same as swapping the numbers round. So 4% of 50 is exactly the same as 50% of 4. When a percentage looks awkward, flip it and it often turns friendly. Let's do it. 4% of 50 — swap it — becomes 50% of 4. And 50% is just a half, so half of 4 is 2. So 4% of 50 is 2. Done in one breath. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 8% of 25? ... and what's 6% of 50? ... Have a proper go before I tell you. ... Ready? 8% of 25 — swap it — is 25% of 8. That's a quarter of 8, which is 2. So 8% of 25 is 2. Now 6% of 50 — swap it — is 50% of 6, which is half of 6, so 3. So 6% of 50 is 3. See? You now know a trick most grown-ups have never even heard of.

■ Say: "Number 87" — "Is over Of"

Quick one — you score 30 out of 40 on a test. What percent is that? ... If you said 75% in a flash, you've already got this. If not, no worries — here comes the trick. To turn a score into a percentage, take the part, divide it by the whole, then multiply by 100. Remember it as is over of: what percent IS 30 OF 40 means 30 over 40. Let's walk it through. 30 divided by 40 is 0.75. Then 0.75 times 100 is 75. So 30 out of 40 is 75%. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what percent is 18 out of 20? ... and what percent is 15 out of 60? ... Have a proper go before I tell you. ... Right, together now. 18 out of 20: 18 divided by 20 is 0.9, and 0.9 times 100 is 90. So 18 out of 20 is 90% — a cracking score. Now 15 out of 60: 15 divided by 60 is 0.25, and 0.25 times 100 is 25. So 15 out of 60 is 25%. That's it — every test score you ever get, you can turn into a percent in seconds.

■ Say: "Number 88" — Multiplier Method (+% or -%)

Try this — take £80 and add 25%. What do you get? ... Under ten seconds? Then you're already using this trick without knowing it. If not, let's learn it right now. To add a percentage in one hit, multiply by 1 plus the percentage as a decimal — so plus 25% means times 1.25, and plus 10% means times 1.1. To take a percentage off, multiply by 1 minus the decimal — minus 25% means times 0.75, minus 10% means times 0.9. One multiply, no extra adding step. So, £80 plus 25%: that's 80 times 1.25. 80 times 1 is 80, and a quarter of 80 is 20, so 80 plus 20 is 100. £80 plus 25% is £100. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's £60 plus 50%? ... and what's £40 minus 10%? ... Have a proper go first. ... Let's check. £60 plus 50% is 60 times 1.5: 60 plus half of 60, which is 30, makes 90. So £90. Now £40 minus 10% is 40 times 0.9: 40 minus 4 is 36. So £36. See? One multiplier does the whole job — go smash the practice.

■ Say: "Number 89" — Chain Two %s with Multipliers

Here's a brain-teaser — prices go up 20%, then down 20%. Are you back where you started? ... If you smelled a trick and said no, you're sharp — most grown-ups get this wrong. If you said yes, brilliant, because you're about to find out why it isn't. The trick: turn each change into a multiplier, then multiply the multipliers together. Up 20% is times 1.2, down 20% is times 0.8. Let's see. 1.2 times 0.8 is 0.96. Times 0.96 means you end up with 96% of what you started with — so it's actually a 4% loss overall, not back to the start. Sneaky! Your turn — pause me if you need to: up 10% then up 10% again — what's the total change? ... and up 50% then down 50%? ... Have a proper think first. ... Let's check. Up 10% twice is 1.1 times 1.1, which is 1.21 — a 21% rise, a bit more than 20. And up 50% then down 50% is 1.5 times 0.5, which is 0.75 — a 25% loss. See? You can now out-think a sale sign — that's proper maths power.

■ Say: "Number 90" — Reverse Percentages

Quick one — a game costs £45 in a half-price sale. What was the full price? ... If you said £90 straight off, you've already got the knack. If not, no worries — this trick works backwards through any sale. Here's how: work out what percentage is LEFT after the discount, turn it into a decimal, and divide the sale price by it. That undoes the change and gives you the original. So, the £45 game: half price means 50% is left, and 50% as a decimal is 0.5. Then 45 divided by 0.5 is 90. So the full price was £90. Your turn — pause me if you need to: a jacket is £60 after 25% off — what was the original price? ... and a book is £27 after 10% off? ... Have a proper go before I tell you. ... Let's check together. 25% off means 75% is left, which is 0.75. And 60 divided by 0.75 is 80 — the jacket was £80. Now the book: 10% off means 90% left, which is 0.9. And 27 divided by 0.9 is 30 — it was £30. See? You can rewind any sale — that's a trick shopkeepers hope you never learn.

■ Say: "Number 91" — Tip Combos

Quick one — you're out for pizza and the bill is £40. What's a 15 percent tip? ... If that popped out in under ten seconds, you're already a tipping champion. If not, stick with me — this one is genuinely useful for life. Here's the secret: every tip is built from 10 percent. 15 percent is 10 percent plus half of it again. 20 percent is just 10 percent doubled. Find 10 percent first and the rest falls out. So, that £40 bill. 10 percent of 40 is 4 — that's £4. Half of £4 is £2. £4 plus £2 is £6. A 15 percent tip on £40 is £6. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's a 20 percent tip on a £35 bill? ... and what's a 15 percent tip on a £60 bill? ... Have a proper go before I tell you. Ready? The £35 bill first: 10 percent of 35 is £3.50. Double it for 20 percent: £7. Now the £60 bill: 10 percent of 60 is £6. Half of £6 is £3. £6 plus £3 is £9 — that's your 15 percent. See? Next time you're out for dinner, you'll have the tip sorted before the grown-ups find their phones.

■ Say: "Number 92" — Use a Fraction for Tidy %s

Here's a quick one — what's 75 percent of 80? ... If you got that in under ten seconds, you already think like this trick. If not, no worries at all — you're about to learn a lovely shortcut. Some percentages are much faster as fractions. 25 percent is a quarter, 50 percent is a half, 75 percent is three quarters, and 60 percent is three fifths. Swap the percentage for its fraction, and a scary sum turns friendly. Let's do 75 percent of 80. 75 percent is three quarters. 80 divided by 4 is 20. 20 times 3 is 60. So 75 percent of 80 is 60. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 25 percent of 64? ... and what's 60 percent of 45? ... Have a proper go before I tell you. Right, let's check together. 25 percent is a quarter, so 64 divided by 4 is 16 — that's it, 16. And 60 percent is three fifths: 45 divided by 5 is 9, and 9 times 3 is 27. So 60 percent of 45 is 27. That's it — you now know a trick most grown-ups don't, so go smash the practice.

Done with this part? Save the audio into OneDrive > Times tables > recordings. Thank you!